Kaizen Languages

Designing adaptive language learning around behaviour, motivation and retention

Role
Founding Product Designer

Company
Kaizen Languages

Timeline
3 years

Focus
Mobile product design / Behavioural UX / Learning systems / Retention design

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Overview

Most language learning apps optimise for streaks.

But learning a language is not simply about consistency.

It's about confidence, motivation and creating feedback loops that help people feel progress.

As the founding product designer at Kaizen Languages, I led the end-to-end design of the mobile experience across iOS and Android.

The product combined:

- behavioural learning principles
- adaptive feedback systems
- writing-based interaction models
- progression design
- gamified motivation loops

...to help users build sustainable learning habits.

The challenge wasn't just teaching language.

It was designing an experience users would return to.

Why this mattered

Language learning products face extremely high churn.

Many users begin highly motivated, but quickly abandon learning due to:

- cognitive fatigue
- lack of visible progress
- repetitive exercises
- low emotional engagement
- inconsistent habits

Retention became one of the most important product challenges.

The opportunity was not simply increasing lesson completion.

It was creating a more adaptive and motivating learning experience built around how people actually sustain habits.

The problem

Many traditional language learning products relied heavily on:

- repetitive drills
- passive learning patterns
- rigid progression systems
- generic feedback

These systems often rewarded task completion rather than meaningful engagement.

Users frequently struggled with:

- motivation drop-off
- confidence anxiety
- lack of personalisation
- inconsistent learning momentum

The challenge became:

How might we design a language learning experience that feels adaptive, rewarding and behaviourally sustainable over time?

Behavioural insights

Motivation drops quickly without visible progress

Users became disengaged when learning felt repetitive or disconnected from meaningful improvement.

Small moments of progress and reinforcement had a significant impact on retention.

Confidence mattered as much as correctness

Many users experienced hesitation around:

- writing
- grammar
- making mistakes
- producing original language

The experience needed to encourage experimentation without creating anxiety.

Learning habits are emotional systems

Consistency was strongly influenced by:

- reward loops
- motivation
- momentum
- emotional feedback
- perceived achievement

The product needed to feel supportive rather than instructional.

Hypothesis

We believed that if we could:

- create more adaptive learning feedback
- reduce anxiety around mistakes
- increase visible progression
- and build lightweight motivational systems

…we could improve long-term engagement and reduce user churn.

Design principles

Design for momentum

The experience should continuously reinforce progress and reduce friction between learning sessions.

Reduce learning anxiety

Users should feel safe experimenting, writing and making mistakes.

Make progression visible

Progress needed to feel tangible, motivating and emotionally rewarding.

Create adaptive interaction loops

Feedback should feel personalised rather than static or generic.

The solution

I designed a mobile-first language learning experience focused on:

- adaptive progression
- behavioural retention systems
- writing-based interaction
- motivational feedback loops
- personalised learning journeys

The product combined structured learning with more flexible and emotionally engaging interaction models.

Mobile-first learning experience

The product was designed natively for:

- iOS
- Android

with interaction patterns optimised around:

- short learning sessions

• habit-building behaviour
• lightweight engagement
• daily consistency

The interface prioritised simplicity, focus and reduced cognitive overload.

Adaptive writing feedback

One of the most innovative parts of the product was an interactive writing system designed to help users practise freeform language production.

Rather than relying solely on rigid exercises, the experience created:

• dynamic feedback loops
• contextual corrections
• confidence reinforcement
• progressive guidance

This encouraged users to engage more actively with language creation.

Behavioural retention systems

The product incorporated behavioural UX principles to support long-term engagement.

These included:

• lightweight progression systems
• motivational reinforcement
• habit-building interaction patterns
• reward feedback loops
• achievement visibility

The goal was not simply increasing usage.

It was helping users maintain sustainable learning momentum.

Personalised learning journeys

The experience adapted around:

• learning progress
• user behaviour
• interaction patterns
• engagement levels

This created a more flexible and responsive learning experience compared to static lesson structures.

Key product decisions

We prioritised confidence-building over rigid correctness

Users disengaged quickly when learning felt punitive or overly instructional.

Encouraging experimentation created stronger engagement.

We focused heavily on writing interaction

Many language products focused primarily on passive recognition tasks.

Writing-based interaction created deeper engagement and more active language production.

We designed for short behavioural loops

The experience was intentionally optimised around lightweight sessions that felt easy to continue consistently.

Reducing friction between sessions became critical for retention.

We treated motivation as a product system

Progress visibility, emotional reinforcement and feedback loops were treated as core product features — not secondary gamification layers.

Validation & iteration

The product evolved continuously through:

- behavioural analysis
- engagement tracking
- user feedback
- iterative testing
- progression refinement

Visible progression improved engagement

Users responded positively when learning progress felt:

- measurable
- rewarding
- emotionally motivating

Progress clarity helped maintain momentum.

Lightweight interaction reduced abandonment

Reducing friction between sessions increased consistency and lowered drop-off.

Users were more likely to continue when learning felt approachable and flexible.

Writing interaction increased emotional investment

Users became more engaged when they could actively produce language rather than simply recognising answers.

This created stronger feelings of ownership and progression.

Impact

Reduced churn significantly

The redesigned onboarding and behavioural learning systems helped reduce churn to below 20%.

Increased learner engagement

Adaptive progression and feedback systems created stronger ongoing learning momentum.

Achieved strong learner satisfaction

The interactive writing experience contributed to a 62% NPS — exceeding industry averages.

Established scalable learning foundations

The product created a flexible mobile-first system capable of supporting future:

- adaptive learning
- AI-assisted education
- personalised progression
- behavioural learning experiences

Reflection

The biggest learning was that successful language learning products are not simply educational systems.

They are behavioural systems.

Retention was driven less by content volume and more by:

- confidence
- emotional reinforcement
- motivation
- progress visibility
- habit sustainability

The project shifted the focus from:

“How do we teach language?”

to:

“How do we help people continue learning?”

Designing for learning behaviour required balancing:

- structure with flexibility
- guidance with experimentation
- progression with emotional motivation

The result was a more adaptive and engaging language learning experience designed around sustainable human behaviour.

Core skills demonstrated

- Product strategy
- Behavioural UX
- Mobile product design

- Learning systems
- Gamification systems
- Retention design
- Interaction design
- Information architecture
- Adaptive product systems
- User research
- Rapid prototyping
- Cross-functional collaboration
- Design systems
- Data-informed product design